

Warning or Wisdom? Semiotic Shift for All Ages

ABSTRACT

This paper compares deep-time warning proposals in nuclear semiotics with deep-time sacred architectures and initiated traditions. It argues that durable monumentality functions as an attractor of interpretive and exploratory behaviour, producing a semiotic pendulum: warning systems risk becoming pilgrimage sites, while 'places (practices, or peoples) of honour' may conversely become ostracised, avoided, or feared. Using semiotic and anthropological frameworks (indexicality, taboo, cultural memory, ritual thresholds, colonial erasure), the paper develops a typology of positive and negative semiosis and models mechanisms of semiotic drift over millennia. It further borrows a virological lens—genetic drift and shift as dynamic analogues for gradual reinterpretation versus abrupt regime-change in message transmission under contact, translation, and institutional takeover. Interrogating the methods by which messages have attempted—or will attempt—to overcome the 'reverse psychology' inherent in both warning markers and sacred artefacts, ~~it concludes with design implications for long-horizon hazard communication.~~

CONFLICT OF INTERPRETATION

This work is a message. The message is one of a system of messages. The message is about both danger and protection. The message communicates the danger of protecting messages themselves, and the sanctity of the profane. The meaning of the message is to communicate the constant flux of meaning, and the impossible problem of communication itself, both within and across time. The danger of interpretation lies all around, above and below you, and below you will find an interpretation of the message. Pay attention.

This was once a place of honour.

The honour is ahead and before us.

MEANING AS TRANSMISSIBLE PSEUDO-LIFE

Meaning is replicated and transmitted through self-similar, sub-systems of fractal replications of sign-signifier relationships. Meaning is always relational, comprising of two 'strands' of attraction and repulsion in a dance. Not dissimilar to the 'arms race' of pathogen and host, meaning is an ever self-replicating, living entity.

SEMIOTIC TOPOLOGY

In order for the ever-evolving and expanding networks of meaning (tethered, however strongly or tentatively, to a single event or sign) to be transmitted, it must be condensed in order to permeate through multiple membranes. Topology of the cell, in which hydrophobic and hydrophilic molecules are prevented from homogenisation for the purposes of function, reveals a modality of message transmission in which semantic and semiotic units of meaning-making must traverse landscapes of oppositional acceptance ("this idea corresponds with my internal belief landscape"/"this 'unknown' can and should be connected to a 'known'") and rejection ("this idea does not relate to these semantic fragments or relationships held in memory"/"this 'unknown' is unrelated or at odds with a 'known', for either logical or sentimental reasons")

SELF VS. NON-SELF: HORIZONTAL AND VERTICAL AXES

In virological landscapes, the genome undergoes point mutations as a result of error-prone polymerases. Each transmission of a message can be seen as a single replication event, as a single replication event inevitably subject to mutation through the 'duplication' of a 'cell' (in this analogy, a human mind) a message (transmissible pathogen or non-self symbiotic organism) operates alongside, in tandem with the self and non-self genetic material of the progenitors from both components, resulting in a progeny state. The 'transmission' of a message may be between two different minds (horizontally; in the dual process of communication and interpretation akin to an 'infection' or epidemiological transmission), or within the same mind (vertically; as in the process of learning/information acquisition, meaning-generation and memory recall akin to a cell proliferation within one host).

Orthogonal to the horizontal and vertical axes of transmission lie the axes of the transmission's permeability -- two modalities of message preservation existing at right angles to the transmission itself.

SEMIOTIC SHIFT: THE HERMETIC AXIS

Initiated practice or tight-knit protection of myth within anthropological culture operates as a membrane reinforcement, preventing information 'leakage' and conserving a level of message authenticity, while allowing for a potentially more catastrophic breakage of system in time (nefarious means of colonial invasion, neutral means of misunderstanding through insufficient context, or even well-intentioned but misguided means of assimilating culture without sufficiently grounded frameworks of understanding), forcing a semiotic analogue of antigenic shift and a change of phenomenological distance (difference in phenotype) over relatively shorter temporal distance.

SEMIOTIC DRIFT: THE HIEROPHANTIC AXIS

Preservation of hierophantic traditionalist norms embed stability within the 'semiotic genome' preventing cataclysmic shift events while subjecting them to slower, more long-standing changes in meaning. They distribute 'code' widely and more redundantly (liturgy, public ritual, calendrical rehearsal, priestly office). This scaffolding preserves the outward phenotype of practice and makes the system less prone to catastrophic rupture. Meaning still changes--inevitably--but tends to do so as slower, cumulative semiotic drift: continuity of form masks gradual reinterpretation, rather than collapsing into sudden re-hosting.

FRAMEWORKS VS. CAGES: CULTURAL ATTEMPTS AT STABILISATION OF ANOMALOUS EXPERIENCE

*Oral frameworks fail under forced assimilation;
institutional frameworks fail under regime capture.*

A framework is a semiotic scaffold that holds anomalous experience without exhausting it: it offers roles, narratives, ritual practice, and community recognition that allow meaning to

be cultivated and to bud organically into insight, obligation, and care. A cage is a containment protocol: when a society lacks (or has dismantled) the scaffold, it substitutes administrative legibility—risk, disorder, deviance, ‘protection’—and ambiguity becomes something to police. This is a pendular inversion: what might be interpreted as socially meaningful is re-encoded as contamination, deception, or disorder, and fear becomes the default Signature^[1], shaping the Signee^[1-1].

These strategies also differ in how they transmit. Oral-relational frameworks store meaning in people and repeated performance—storytelling, apprenticeship, ritual thresholds—spreading through close contact like a stabilising microbiome. Institutional-documentary frameworks store legitimacy in documents and credentialed systems—medicine, law, education, mass media—propagating through broadcast networks more like viral transmission: high reproduction at scale, rapid ‘variant’ replacement under moral panic or regime capture,^[2] and frequent simplification as concepts move between hosts. Bacterial lineages tend to change more slowly in part because DNA polymerases proofread and repair, whereas many RNA viruses mutate rapidly because their polymerases are error-prone.

The Danger Below

1. Within the Tetradic, Lexicomythographic framework of semiology. See "Deixis (n.)", ARIA|DNE, ERA_VI.↩↩
2. A stark Western case of forced shift is the assault on Berlin’s Institute for Sexual Science and the burning of its library and archives in 1933. When archives are destroyed, a community’s ability to demonstrate continuity, inherit vocabulary, and maintain lineage is severed, making hostile re-description easier to install and harder to contest. In an institutional culture this becomes a single-point failure: remove the records, training lineages, and public legitimacy, and the vacuum is filled by cages—pathologised labels and boundary-policing rhetoric that scale efficiently through bureaucratic systems. Where meaning is institutionally stored, frameworks require redundancy—archives, oral history, community institutions, clinical standards, and legal protections—so that no single raid, panic, or policy shift can flip the semiotic regime overnight.↩